Back to Services and clinics

Newborn services

Providing specialised care and support for babies who need extra medical attention after birth.

Where to find this service

Where to find this service

Joan Kirner Women'...

What we do

Newborn Services at Joan Kirner Women's and Children's (JKWC), Sunshine Hospital is Victoria's newest Neonatal Intensive Care Unit (NICU). Each year we care for about 2,000 babies and support more than 7,000 births.

Our 30-cot unit combines intensive-care, high-dependency and special-care cots. Planning is under way to add nine more cots to meet the needs of our growing community.

A multidisciplinary team of neonatologists, nurses, allied-health clinicians and support staff works together to deliver family-centred, evidence-based care to the tiniest and most vulnerable patients in Melbourne's west.

Services and facilities

Neonatal intensive and special care

Combined intensive-care, high-dependency and special-care Nursery cots with 24-hour monitoring.

Neonatal Point-of-Care Ultrasound

Bedside ultrasound for rapid assessment and guidance of procedures.

Neonatal follow-up clinic

Developmental surveillance for babies at higher risk, from discharge through early childhood.

Neonatal Maternal-Fetal Medicine clinic

Joint obstetric–neonatal review for complex pregnancies and newborns with anticipated care needs.

Continued Care at Home

Home nursing and allied-health support if your baby still needs specialised care after discharge.

Allied-health and paediatric partnerships

Physiotherapy, dietetics, speech pathology and paediatric specialty clinics delivered with Women's and Children's programs.

Collaborative services

Close links with maternity, paediatric and community teams to ensure seamless care.

Who this service is for

Families in Melbourne's west whose babies need specialised or intensive neonatal care, as well as infants transferred from across Victoria through the Paediatric Infant Perinatal Emergency Retrieval (PIPER) service.

Referrals

External clinicians should contact PIPER for advice or transfer arrangements in line with Victorian neonatal retrieval protocols.

Transfer to another hospital

When your baby no longer needs intensive or high-dependency care, we arrange transfer to the newborn unit closest to your home.

Opening hours

24 hours, 7 days a week.

Visiting hours

- Parents and carers: 24/7 access, with one parent able to stay overnight.
- Other visitors: 2 pm – 8 pm daily.
- Maximum three people at the cot (including parents/carers).
- Children under 12, other than the patient's siblings, are not permitted.

Your questions answered

Seeing your baby

Parents have unrestricted, 24-hour access. Each cot has a day-bed for one parent to stay overnight. If you're away from the ward, phone updates are available. A secure camera link can be arranged when clinically appropriate.

Discussing your baby's treatment

Our team conducts ward rounds beginning at 9:00am and concluding at 11:00am. This is the best opportunity for you to meet the team and have discussions around your baby's treatment, as well as receive updates. If you are unable to attend during these hours, you can ask to speak to someone from our team when you next attend.

When you can take your baby home

Discharge is based on your baby feeding well, maintaining temperature, gaining weight and no longer needing breathing support. Your care team starts preparing you for home well in advance.

Caring for your baby at home

Before discharge you'll practise feeding, bathing and giving medicines. Our Continued Care at Home nurses can visit or call to support you after you leave hospital.

More information

Interpreter services

Face-to-face and telephone interpreters are available 24 hours a day – just ask your nurse.

Feedback, complaints and compliments

We welcome feedback at any time. Use the Feedback at Western Health form to tell us what we did well or what we can improve.

Helpful resources

- **EVE: Pregnancy Companion app –** Trusted pregnancy information and tracking.
- **PIPER Parent Information –** Advice on moving babies closer to home.
- **Raising Children Network –** Guides on neonatal intensive care and bringing home a premature or sick baby.

Related topics

Newborn Emergency Transpor...

Want to hear more from us?

Subscribe to our Newsletter